STEP 1

# Market & User Research

## From meeting notes to honest commitment closure

Prepared for the Fireflies.ai Product Management Launchpad capstone

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Purpose: understand what happens to a commitment after a meeting ends, identify evidence-backed friction, and establish what still needs validation before selecting a product solution.

| Evidence category | How this report treats it |
|---|---|
| Case-study facts | Requirements and baseline supplied in the Airtribe case study; treated as assignment inputs, not independently audited product facts. |
| Interview evidence | Participant-reported workflows and examples captured in the supplied interview tracker and takeaways. |
| Interpretation | Patterns inferred from multiple observations; explicitly labelled as interpretations rather than proven causes. |
| Hypotheses | Potential explanations or opportunities that require further validation. |
| Unknowns | Gaps that prevent a reliable conclusion; retained instead of filled with assumptions. |

# 1. Executive summary

This research examines the work that happens after a meeting commitment is spoken: how it is recorded, who accepts responsibility, how progress and dependencies are followed up, and how the final outcome becomes known. The case study frames the product opportunity as improving explicit commitment resolution from 28% within 14 days to 45% within six months. These figures are assignment-provided baseline and target values, not results produced by this research.

The available interview material shows a varied set of work practices rather than one uniform process. Participants described combinations of Jira or CRM tasks, spreadsheets, email, chat, calendar reminders, personal notes, and meeting notes. Some examples indicate manual follow-up, dependency delays, incomplete capture, or rework. However, several interviews did not reconstruct one specific meeting commitment from agreement through to a verified terminal outcome.

The updated tracker now contains P01–P15 records, including P14 and P15. P15 is flagged by the source notes as potentially duplicative of the P09/P10 scenario, so the final distinct-participant count should remain provisional until that is checked.

The defensible early conclusion is therefore that follow-through can be fragmented across tools and people, making the state and outcome of some work difficult to verify. The evidence does not yet establish that unclear ownership is the single dominant cause of unresolved commitments, nor does it quantify how often each failure mode occurs.

## Key takeaways

- Tracking is distributed: participants described multiple systems and personal methods rather than one consistent commitment lifecycle.
- Manual follow-up is present: examples include email follow-ups for cross-team dependencies and manual task creation from meeting chat.
- Capture and interpretation can be imperfect: one participant reported that client language or slang can make tasks difficult to understand and that some tasks may be left unnoted.
- Dependencies and changing requirements can delay work even when a task is tracked.
- Final outcomes are often unverified in the current evidence: delay, active work, and unresolved status are not interchangeable.
- Further targeted interviews and record reconciliation are needed before selecting a primary barrier with high confidence.

# 2. Research objective and questions

Objective: understand how commitments move—or fail to move—from a spoken agreement to an explicitly recorded outcome, while distinguishing commitments made in meetings from general work tasks, dependencies, and deadlines.

## Core research questions

1. Think of one specific commitment from a recent meeting. What exactly was agreed, and by whom?
2. Where was the commitment recorded after the meeting, and who created or updated that record?
3. Was the proposed owner explicitly willing to take responsibility? How was that acceptance made clear?
4. What deadline or completion criteria were agreed, and were they understood the same way by everyone involved?
5. What happened next? Which reminders, messages, tools, or handoffs were needed?
6. Were there dependencies, scope changes, missing information, or competing priorities? How did people respond?
7. How did you know the commitment was done, reassigned, or deliberately dropped? Where was that outcome recorded?

### Research hypotheses to test (not findings)

| Hypothesis | Evidence that would support it | Evidence that would weaken it |
|---|---|---|
| H1. Commitments are lost during transfer from meeting notes to a work system. | Specific commitment is present in notes but absent from the user's normal task system; manual re-entry is described. | Commitments are reliably created in the team's work system with little manual transfer. |
| H2. Ownership is often assumed rather than explicitly accepted. | A named person was listed as owner without agreement or awareness, causing delay or dispute. | Participants consistently confirm acceptance and know who owns the next step. |
| H3. Follow-up depends on personal reminders and repeated messages. | A specific commitment needed manual reminders or follow-ups before progress/outcome was known. | Existing workflows automatically surface relevant work and rarely require extra chasing. |
| H4. Dependency or requirement ambiguity is a major cause of delay. | A concrete commitment stalled due to another team, missing data, unclear requirements, or environment mismatch. | Most unresolved commitments are not dependency-related, or have clear escalation and closure paths. |
| H5. The final outcome is not consistently recorded. | Work was completed, reassigned, or dropped but no system reflected that outcome. | The final state is consistently and accurately recorded in the system people already use. |

## 3. Research approach and participant coverage

The research approach is qualitative and episode-based: ask participants to reconstruct a recent commitment and follow its trail through records, actions, dependencies, and outcome. This is more diagnostic than asking only about general habits because it can distinguish a remembered pattern from a specific observed sequence.

### Stakeholder groups to cover

| Stakeholder | What to learn | Coverage / gap in current materials |
|---|---|---|
| Individual contributors | How commitments are captured, accepted, prioritized, progressed, and closed. | Most documented participants are individual contributors or technical specialists. |
| People coordinating or depending on others | How cross-team handoffs, blockers, and revised timelines are managed. | Some coverage through project coordination, engineering dependencies, and business analysis examples. |
| Managers / team leads | How visibility is gained without creating surveillance or unnecessary status work. | At least one team lead / decision-maker record is present; broader manager coverage is limited. |
| Administrators / tool owners | Integration, permissions, workflow constraints, and governance. | Not clearly established as a distinct stakeholder group in the tracker. |
| Buyers / budget owners | What measurable value would justify adoption or expansion. | Coverage is not established in the current tracker. |

### Participant record reconciliation

The updated workbook, “Fireflies_Interview_Guide_and_Tracker_Updated_P15.xlsx,” now includes populated records for P01–P15, including new takeaways for P14 (SAP MM Consultant) and P15 (Data Engineer). This resolves the earlier gap in the number of populated tracker records. However, 15 populated records do not yet prove 15 independent participants: the P15 takeaways explicitly flag that its Snowflake-to-Databricks dependency example closely resembles P09/P10. Before the final submission claims 15 distinct interviews, verify whether P15 is a separate participant and interview or a duplicate/repeated account. The tracker also notes that some interview dates are based on transcript or note dates and still require confirmation.

Dates in the tracker are not uniformly confirmed. Some are explicitly marked for confirmation or inferred from transcript upload dates. Before final submission, confirm actual interview dates, role labels, consent for any direct quotations, and whether each record represents a distinct participant.

### Sampling limitations

- The available sample is a convenience sample, not a representative survey of Fireflies users or the wider market.
- The current evidence is weighted toward individual contributors and technical roles; distinct administrator and buyer perspectives are under-documented.

- Several transcripts are multilingual or machine-transcribed, which can introduce transcription errors. Do not use verbatim quotations without checking the source audio/text and confirming permission.
- Examples vary in strength: some reconstruct an event, while others describe a general workflow. These should not be treated as equivalent evidence.
- The material does not provide a denominator of all commitments observed, so failure-mode prevalence and causal contribution cannot be calculated.

## 4. What the interview evidence currently supports

The following synthesis uses the participant takeaways and tracker entries. It intentionally avoids treating every task delay as a failure of a meeting commitment.

| Evidence item | Reported behavior / episode | What it supports | What it does not establish |
|---|---|---|---|
| P02 — AI Assurance | Described Jira, Google Sheets, and an Excel tracker maintained by a team lead; notes vary between AI-generated and manual methods. Reported that client accents/slang can make some tasks hard to understand and that tasks may sometimes be left unnoted. | Tracking and note-taking can be distributed; task capture or interpretation can be imperfect. | Does not quantify frequency or prove that a specific meeting commitment remained unresolved for 14 days. |
| P03 — Team lead / decision-maker | Described calendar reminders and monitoring across a large work portfolio; a report example was illustrative rather than a traced commitment. | Managers use reminders and status checks to manage work. | Does not establish a specific failed commitment or prove that management visibility is the primary barrier. |
| P04 — IT administration / operations | Described tickets, shared queues, updates to assignees, and follow-up with parent-company support; no single commitment was traced end to end. | Ownership and progress may involve shared queues and cross-organization follow-up. | Does not prove a specific meeting commitment was missed or unresolved. |
| P05 — DevOps | Reported that a forensic-technology task described as due that day was still not ready about a week later, and testing found requirements were not met, causing rework. Exact agreement, owner acceptance, and final outcome need confirmation. | A reported delivery episode involving delay and requirement mismatch/rework. | Does not establish a fully verified meeting commitment or its final resolution state. |
| P06 — Quantitative research | Described regular meeting/task workflows and follow-up practices; a client point was reportedly omitted from minutes and later added after a client reply. | Meeting documentation can omit information and require later correction. | Does not establish that the omission caused a missed deadline or unresolved commitment. |
| P07 — Tax operations | Described queue-based task pickup and strict client submission deadlines, including late work when next-level review is pending. | Work can be deadline-driven and queue-based. | No specific meeting commitment with confirmed owner, deadline, and terminal outcome was traced. |
| P08 — Project coordination | Described coordinating between project management and delivery teams, clarifying requirements, and scheduling internal clarification when knowledge transfer is insufficient. | Cross-team interpretation and requirement clarification can create coordination work. | Does not establish a specific commitment failure or quantify its prevalence. |
| P09 / P10 — Data engineering | Described a Snowflake-to-Databricks dependency, follow-up by email, creation of a Jira ticket, and | Cross-team dependencies can require manual follow-up and may remain ongoing while technical ambiguity is resolved. | The evidence does not establish explicit acceptance, a clear response deadline, a final outcome, or that the |

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| | ongoing technical/environment mismatch. | | dependency was a formal meeting commitment. |
| P11 — Senior design engineering | Described an agreement to provide units by a weekend; resource availability threatened the deadline and others were informed 2–3 days beforehand. Final delivery or a revised agreed date was not confirmed. | People may proactively renegotiate or flag a deadline risk; personal task lists and email are used. | Does not establish eventual delivery, explicit reassignment, deliberate dropping, or confirmed meeting origin. |
| P12 — Talent acquisition / RPO | Described high-volume candidate follow-ups and the risk of accidentally missing a follow-up; also described delays while waiting for client feedback. | High-volume follow-up and external dependencies can create risk. | The transcript does not trace a specific missed meeting commitment through to a final outcome. |
| P13 — Business analysis | Described manually creating CRM tasks from meeting chat with assignees and end dates. A report due within three days was delayed by poor SQL data quality; remaining work reportedly took one day after data arrived. | A concrete workflow for transferring meeting action points into CRM tasks; dependencies/data quality can delay deliverables. | Exact delivery timing and formal closure were not confirmed; the delayed report is not by itself proof of an unresolved meeting commitment. |
| P14 — SAP MM Consultant | Described daily progress calls, emailed minutes of meeting, Smartsheet project tracking, Box project documentation, and a ticketing portal. Missing business-user data delayed planned user-acceptance testing and prompted repeated reminder emails. Late business/finance requirements sometimes led to rework, retesting, or project stoppage. | Moderate evidence of external data dependencies, repeated follow-up, written traceability, late scope changes, and rework. | No single meeting commitment was traced through exact agreement, accepted ownership, deadline, and verified completed/reassigned/dropped outcome. A project delay or stoppage alone is not proof of unresolved commitment. |
| P15 — Data Engineer (sample-quality flag) | Described a Snowflake-to-Databricks dependency: a contact was tagged and asked for code/context, the request was reportedly forgotten, the participant followed up after roughly one to two days, and was directed to create a Jira ticket. The issue remained ongoing due to environment/table differences. | Moderate evidence of cross-team follow-up friction and an email-to-ticket handoff; potentially relevant to continuity between a request and its work record. | Meeting origin, explicit owner acceptance, response deadline, final outcome, and downstream impact are unconfirmed. The example closely resembles P09/P10; verify independence before counting it as a separate evidence point. |

# 5. Cross-interview synthesis

| Emerging pattern | Evidence strength at this stage | Interpretation | Next validation |
|---|---|---|---|
| Work is tracked across multiple places. | Moderate: several participants named multiple tools or personal systems. | Context can be fragmented, but fragmentation alone does not prove poor outcomes. | For a specific commitment, compare meeting notes, task tracker, messages, and final state. |
| Some handoffs require manual follow-up. | Moderate: cross-team follow-up appears in several accounts. | Follow-up effort may be a product opportunity if it is frequent and avoidable. | Ask who followed up, how many times, how long it took, and what happened after. |
| Task capture or interpretation can be incomplete. | Low-to-moderate: direct reported example, but not a quantified pattern. | Improving capture may help some cases, but extraction improvement is out of scope for the capstone. | Check what was actually written in notes and whether the user could correct it. |
| Dependencies and unclear requirements can delay work. | Moderate for delay mechanisms; low for direct link to 14-day resolution. | Not every unresolved item is an accountability problem; some require unblock/renegotiation. | Separate blocked, late, done, reassigned, and dropped states in the event reconstruction. |

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| Explicit closure is not always demonstrated in the evidence. | Low: final outcomes often unknown in the available transcripts. | Outcome visibility is a promising area to investigate, not yet a proven dominant barrier. | Ask how the participant knew the work was done, reassigned, or deliberately dropped and where that was recorded. |

Research interpretation: the most defensible provisional problem area is the continuity between a spoken agreement and a verifiable outcome. The available evidence does not justify narrowing the primary cause to ownership ambiguity alone.

# 6. Product teardown: current Fireflies experience

Source boundary: this teardown is based on the supplied capstone brief, not a fresh hands-on audit of a live Fireflies account. Product claims below should therefore be described as case-study context unless separately verified in the product.

| Area | Case-study description | Implication for the capstone | Verification needed |
|---|---|---|---|
| Meeting capture | Fireflies records meetings and provides transcripts and summaries. | The solution should build on existing meeting capture rather than rebuild it. | Verify the actual current experience, permissions, and relevant screens in a live account. |
| Action-item extraction | The brief states that Fireflies identifies action items and can send outputs to other tools through integrations. | The proposed experience should improve follow-through after extraction. | Inspect extracted action items, editing controls, ownership fields, and available integrations. |
| Post-meeting distribution | A summary email typically goes to meeting attendees. | Broadcasting information is not the same as ensuring one person accepts ownership and records an outcome. | Inspect the email and its links/actions; note exactly what users can do from it. |
| Lifecycle visibility | The case frames Fireflies as having limited visibility into whether extracted commitments were completed. | The design opportunity is explicit, honest closure within the product and existing workflows. | Verify current task/status capabilities before describing any missing functionality as a product fact. |
| Workflow integration | The brief emphasizes connecting to Slack, project trackers, and calendars rather than becoming a new work-management destination. | Prefer a thin coordination layer and use existing systems where feasible. | Identify actual supported connectors and the limits of each in the current product. |

## Current-state teardown checklist

- Capture the post-meeting summary and action-item UI with date/context, using a test or permitted account.
- Record whether an action item can be edited, dismissed, assigned, or linked to a person—and what the UI says about consent.
- Inspect whether task status can be changed and whether Done, reassignment, and deliberate dropping are distinct outcomes.
- Inspect whether changes persist and whether they are visible to meeting attendees, managers, or only the user.
- Inspect current integration choices and document any handoff friction without assuming unsupported connectors.

# 7. Competitive and substitute workflow analysis

The case brief identifies project trackers, Slack messages, stand-ups, and personal to-do lists as existing substitutes. The comparison below describes workflow categories and likely trade-offs; it is not a verified feature-by-feature competitor benchmark.

| Workflow / substitute | Why teams use it | Potential weakness for meeting commitments | Research question |
|---|---|---|---|
| Project trackers (e.g., Jira or CRM task records reported by participants) | Structured tasks, assignees, status, dates, comments, and existing team habits. | Meeting commitments may need manual re-entry; the source | How often is re-entry needed, and does the task preserve the original agreement? |

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| | | context and explicit owner acceptance may be lost. | |
| Chat (e.g., Slack or Teams) | Fast coordination, clarifications, and lightweight follow-up. | Commitments can be buried in message streams; a message does not necessarily mean acceptance or closure. | How do users distinguish a promise from discussion and know when it is closed? |
| Stand-ups and recurring status meetings | Shared updates, blocker escalation, and renegotiation of deadlines. | Status may be repeated verbally without a durable, explicit terminal state. | What gets carried forward repeatedly, and where is the final outcome recorded? |
| Personal notes / notebooks / reminders | Flexible, low-friction, and controlled by the individual. | Low shared visibility and limited continuity when work crosses people or teams. | When do people move an item into a shared system, and what causes them not to? |
| Email and calendar reminders | Useful for formal confirmation, deadlines, and follow-up trails. | Information can be distributed across threads and reminders may prompt action without recording resolution. | How many follow-ups are needed, and is the final state written back to the task system? |
| Meeting assistant / summary workflow | Captures discussion and surfaces summaries/action points. | Extraction alone may not establish accepted ownership or verified closure. | What can users do after extraction today, and which steps still happen manually? |

Competitive research limitation: no claims are made here about current vendor-specific feature parity, market share, or superiority. A later competitor teardown should use dated public product documentation and hands-on observations, and should cite the source for each product capability.

## 8. Stakeholder map

| Stakeholder | Primary job / interest | Potential tension | Research focus |
|---|---|---|---|
| Commitment owner / individual contributor | Understand the ask, agree to ownership, complete or renegotiate the work, and avoid unnecessary admin. | Visibility can help coordination but may feel like surveillance or an imposed obligation. | What proves acceptance? What information and controls are necessary to close honestly? |
| Manager / team lead | Understand delivery risks, dependencies, and workload; unblock work and coordinate priorities. | Needs visibility without turning every action into a monitoring signal or creating more status work. | What decision does the manager make with status data? What visibility is proportionate? |
| Administrator / tool owner | Maintain integrations, permissions, governance, and acceptable data flows. | More workflow automation can create permission, retention, or integration complexity. | Which integrations and controls are required for a pilot? |
| Buyer / budget owner | See measurable productivity or coordination value and justify purchase/expansion. | May value team-level outcomes while end users bear the extra work. | What measurable value would influence renewal, conversion, or expansion? |
| Dependent teammate / partner team | Receive a clear request, provide input, surface blockers, and know when a handoff is accepted. | The original owner may not control the dependency or the other team's priorities. | How are dependencies, response expectations, and revised dates agreed? |

## 9. Anticipated barriers to honest closure

These are initial research hypotheses informed by the case brief and interview material—not a ranked or quantified list of root causes.

| Potential barrier | Current basis | What would confirm it |
|---|---|---|
| Commitment is not transferred into a durable task record. | Case brief describes a summary sent broadly; some interviews describe manual transfer from meeting chat or mixed note-taking. | Trace a specific commitment from meeting to task system and measure how often transfer is missed. |
| Ownership is assumed rather than accepted. | Case brief flags consent and ownership as design constraints; current interviews do not consistently establish explicit acceptance. | Find specific cases where assignment was not acknowledged or the person disputed ownership. |
| Progress and final outcome are spread across tools. | Multiple tools and manual tracking methods appear in participant accounts. | Reconstruct the record trail and ask where the final state is recorded. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Dependencies, unclear requirements, or changing scope block progress. | Several accounts describe dependency follow-up, data/environment mismatch, or clarification work. | Classify a specific commitment as blocked and determine whether a revised plan or explicit outcome was recorded. |
| Follow-up creates friction or notification fatigue. | Plausible from the multi-tool workflows and the capstone's stated constraints; direct evidence is limited. | Ask participants about reminder usefulness, ignored alerts, frequency, and the cost of checking status. |

## 10. Recommended next research actions

8. Verify whether P15 is an independent participant/interview or a duplicate/repeated account resembling P09/P10; confirm the actual dates for P14 and P15 and any other records marked for confirmation.
9. Confirm dates, stakeholder types, and whether each participant represents a distinct completed interview.
10. Conduct targeted follow-ups with at least two managers/team leads, one administrator/tool owner, and one buyer or budget owner if feasible.
11. For each follow-up, reconstruct one recent commitment and record: exact ask, owner agreement, deadline, recording location, reminders, blockers, and verified outcome.
12. Label each example as a meeting commitment, a general task, or a dependency request; do not combine these categories.
13. Ask permission before using direct quotes; verify exact wording against the source and anonymize sensitive information.
14. Complete a hands-on Fireflies teardown and record dated screenshots/observations separately from claims stated in the capstone brief.
15. Perform a sourced competitor review of current alternatives only after the current workflow is documented.

## 11. Step 1 conclusion

The research so far suggests that the path from a spoken commitment to a verified outcome may be fragmented across meeting notes, work trackers, email, chat, and personal reminders. Participants described manual follow-up, dependency delays, and occasional capture or interpretation issues. Yet many available examples do not establish a complete meeting-commitment lifecycle or a verified final outcome.

Accordingly, the next step should not assume that ownership ambiguity is already proven to be the primary barrier. Step 2 should frame the problem around the evidence-supported continuity gap, then compare candidate causes against the strongest specific examples and explicitly retain uncertainty where evidence is incomplete.